

Uncovering Scientific Methodology in Qur'anic Discourse

Translation of the Original Arabic

BOOKS-IN-BRIEF

RAZAN SAKKAL



Uṣūl al-Manhajīyyah al-ʿIlmiyyah fī al-Qurʾān al-Karīm

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Razan Sakkal

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Mukhtaṣar Kitāb Uṣūl al-Manhajīyyah al-ʿIlmiyyah fī al-Qurʾān al-Karīm

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IIIT Books-In-Brief Series

The IIIT Books-In-Brief Series is a valuable collection of the Institute's key publications written in condensed form designed to give readers a core understanding of the main contents of the original. Produced in a short, easy to read, time-saving format, these companion synopses offer a close, carefully written overview of the larger publication and it is hoped will stimulate readers into further exploration of the original.

The Qur'an, while not a scientific manual, provides a framework for the pursuit of *'ilm* that closely reflects the core principles of the scientific method: curiosity, observation, reasoning, and consistency. Many scholars—both classical and modern—have commented that the Qur'an encourages observation, critical thinking, and the pursuit of knowledge in ways that resemble the scientific method. In this work, a translation of Razan Sakkal's original Arabic book *Mukhtaṣar Kitāb Uṣūl al-Manhajīyyah al-ʿIlmiyyah fī al-Qurʾān al-Karīm*, Sakkal shows how aspects of scientific methodology are found in the Qur'an.

The Qur'an's repeated call to observe the natural world – from the structure of the cosmos to the patterns in living organisms – invites us to discover the inherent order within creation. Sakkal argues that this focus on empirical observation reflects a fundamental part of the scientific method, where knowledge begins with careful engagement with the physical world. She also points out that the Qur'an consistently encourages rational reflection and critical thinking, viewing these elements as similar to the process of forming hypotheses and engaging in evidence-based reasoning central to scientific inquiry.

In her interpretation, Sakkal highlights the Qur'anic use of the term *āyah*, which refers to both scriptural verses and natural phenomena. She argues that this dual meaning intentionally links revelation with the observable universe, suggesting that both should be studied systematically. Sakkal also emphasizes the Qur'an's high regard for

acquiring knowledge, its acknowledgment of consistent natural laws, and its criticism of blindly following inherited beliefs – all of which, she claims, form a cognitive framework similar to scientific methodology. Through this analysis, Sakkal depicts the Qur'an not as a scientific manual, but as a text that actively promotes the intellectual habits essential to scientific thinking.

Editor's note: Usage of the terms “*ilm*” and “science” in this work

Since the concepts of “*ilm*” and “science” are central to this work, and because the use of the term *‘ilm* in Arabic and its translation into English (especially as “science”) can be confusing for readers, it is helpful to discuss the usage of these terms and their intended meaning within the content of this work. Sakkal's use of the term *‘ilm* reflects how it was understood during the pre-modern and early modern periods in the Arab-Islamic world, and that is a more general, unifying, and holistic view of knowledge. The pursuit of *‘ilm* within the Islamic ethos, be it contextually worldly or religious, is framed within Islamic beliefs and values that guide the processes of acquiring knowledge. Whatever field of knowledge a Muslim achieves specialization in, be it mathematics, philosophy, engineering, medicine, or religion, falls under the notion of *‘ilm*, and one possessing it is given the title *‘ālim*, regardless of the disciplinary content. Thus, the derived agentive nouns *‘ālim* (singular) and *‘ulamā* (plural) are used to describe both scientists and Muslim clerics or scholars of Islam – that is, individuals with expert knowledge in either worldly or religious and spiritual matters. *‘ilm* in this sense is both broad and unifying. The term *‘ilm* and its derivatives, as used by Sakkal, also include the understanding of *‘ilm* as “science” in the sense of “knowledge” or “a system of knowledge,” that is, as a systematic approach to understanding the natural world through observation, experimentation, and evidence-based reasoning, often seen as a cornerstone of rational thought and decision-making.

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INTRODUCTION

The Qur'an presents not only a comprehensive framework of spiritual and ethical guidance but also a distinctive model of systematic thought and methodological reasoning. This short book aims to examine the Qur'anic approach to *manhaj* (method) and *manhajyyah* (methodology) by exploring how the sacred text cultivates rational inquiry, integrates moral values, and appeals to various forms of evidence in its discourse. Far from offering abstract or disjointed teachings, the Qur'an engages the human intellect, sense perception, and spiritual conscience through a coherent and purposeful methodology inviting readers to reflect deeply on their lives and the world around them while fostering a holistic understanding of faith and existence.

Chapter One

INTRODUCTION TO KEY CONCEPTS

Understanding the Concept of "Method" (*Manhaj*) and "Methodology" (*Manhajyyah*), and Key Related Concepts

Understanding the Concept of "Method" (*Manhaj*): Linguistic and Technical Definition

Linguistically, the term method (*manhaj*) means a path or road and is linked to clarity, transparency, and avoiding deviation. Generally, a method refers to any approach that guides to a specific goal that someone aims to achieve. In science, it signifies a set of general rules that direct the process of discovering or proving the truth. In scientific terms, a method involves a system of rules that govern scientific research, conducted according to an organized plan that includes a series of mental or sensory activities within an epistemological or philosophical framework. This structure embodies the internal system of the method, which forms part of a broader external system: methodology.

The Concept of "Methodology" (*Manhajyyah*) and Its Relation to Method

Methodology (*manhajyyah*) refers to the science of research methods or the science of methods. Although methods vary across different scientific disciplines, they share a core set of principles and rules. Methodology, or the science of methods, focuses on identifying and defining these common elements by generalizing and extracting the essential features of methods used in various fields. From this, it develops a general logical approach for seeking truth, including the principles and assumptions involved in the ongoing process of refinement between the researcher and the objects of study—starting from the beginning of the research until the achievement of truth and knowledge. Therefore, methodology is broader and more inclusive than a single method; it is the science of designing, applying, and implementing research methods—essentially the “method of methods.” Meanwhile, a method consists of the rules, tools, procedures, and techniques that are part of the methodology.

Science (*‘ilm*), Knowledge (*Ma‘rifah*), and Their Relationship

The method is closely linked to important concepts, foremost among them science (*‘ilm*), which is both the goal of the method and the field in which it is activated, followed by the concept of knowledge (*ma‘rifah*). Linguistically, science is the comprehension of something in its true essence, while knowledge is understanding something through contemplation and reflection on its effects. Disagreements exist over how to distinguish between these two concepts, yet both relate to the idea of comprehension. As perception tools are linked to two components—the subject (the matter of study) and the method (the mental steps followed by the researcher to gain knowledge)—knowledge comprises both subject and method. It is broader than science and encompasses both scientific and non-scientific forms of knowledge. Scientific knowledge closely aligns conceptually with science, which is fundamentally based on method. Science is characterized by its unique method; it is essentially a way of thinking and a method of research more than a mere collection of information and laws. Moreover, the concept of science is not confined to natural sciences based on sensory experience and the experimental method alone. It broadly includes comprehension of matters as they truly are, based on evidence. Thus, any subject that can lead to certainty through an appropriate method falls under the realm of science.

Theory of Knowledge (*Nazriyyat al-Ma‘rifah*) and Epistemology

Studies refer to both the theory of knowledge (*nazriyyat al-ma‘rifah*) and epistemology due to their relation to methodology. The “theory of knowledge” arose as a philosophical field that addresses the possibility, nature, source, value, and limits of knowledge, as well as the ways to attain it. Epistemology (the science of sciences), on the other hand, critically examines the principles, assumptions, and results of various sciences, aiming to clarify their logical origin and objective value. Methodology (or *methodologia*) is closely connected to epistemology, as critically examining the principles and assumptions of sciences requires first examining the method followed to arrive at them—which is the specific domain of methodology.

The Concept of Method (*Manhaj*) in the Qur’an and Its Main Characteristics

The Concept of Method (*Manhaj*) in the Qur’an and Related Terms

The root *n-h-j* appears only once in the Qur’an, in the word *minhāj* and in the verse: “...To each of you We prescribed a law and a method [*minhāj*]...” (5:48). This word’s usage here does not deviate from its linguistic meaning of a clear and evident path. The verse pairs *manhaj* (method) with *sharī‘ah* (moral-legal framework). According to some scholars, *sharī‘ah* refers to the religion, while *manhaj* refers to the means through which it is known.

In addition to its link with *sharī‘ah*, the concept of method (*manhaj*) in the Qur’an is associated with several core Qur’anic terms such as path (*sabīl*), way (*ṭarīq*), and straight path (*ṣirāṭ*). These all form a central semantic field that shares the linguistic meaning of a clear and easy path. In the Qur’an, these terms are used with a distinct religious/technical meaning, as seen in phrases like “the path of God” and “the straight path,” or in the comparison between “method” and “*sharī‘ah*.”

This semantic field also connects to central Qur’anic concepts such as guidance (*hidāyah*), which shares with method the foundational idea of a path leading to a goal. Method represents the path itself, while guidance refers to traversing it or indicating how to do so.

Another central concept is *‘ilm*, mentioned over 850 times in the Qur’an. It often appears in association with method (*manhaj*) and the straight path (*al-*

ṣirāṭ al-mustaqīm), and is closely related to the concept of *maʿrifah*. In Qurʾanic usage, the term *ʿilm* refers to both human knowledge and divine knowledge, whereas *maʿrifah* is limited to human knowledge. *Maʿrifah* is usually tied to sensory perception and presented as acquired awareness supported by signs or evidence. *ʿIlm*, on the other hand, encompasses both necessary (innate) and acquired knowledge.

Thus, *ʿilm* is broader than *maʿrifah* in terms of scope, encompassing both divine and human knowledge, and within human knowledge, both innate and acquired forms. However, in the context of general scientific (*ʿilmī*) research, *ʿilm* (meaning science or “a system of knowledge” acquired through observation, study, and reasoning) is more specific than *maʿrifah* because the method (*manhaj*)—being the foundation of *ʿilm*—defines it. In contrast, *maʿrifah* includes both scientific and non-scientific understanding.

Characteristics of the Qurʾanic Method (*Manhaj*)

The Qurʾanic method (*manhaj*) is distinguished by a set of characteristics, foremost among them being that it is divinely sourced. It combines foundational constancy with practical flexibility. It is not limited to a specific era or environment but is ever-renewing, providing what is compatible with sound human reasoning in every time and place. The Qurʾanic method is also balanced and precise, aiming for *civilizational methodization* (*al-minhāj al-ḥaḍārī*), which includes the methodization of thought, research, and action. Its primary goals are guidance and the attainment of truth.

These characteristics are attributed to the Qurʾanic method because the Qurʾan is a divine revelation. Its divine origin is the foundational attribute upon which all other characteristics are built. This divine source, however, does not negate the human role in engaging with the Qurʾan—to extract, formulate, renew, and implement it. This complete, comprehensive, and balanced method requires active human effort to uncover, understand, and act upon it through scholarly interpretation. Thus, there is an interaction between the absoluteness of its source and the relativity of human endeavor in striving to attain it, and between the perfection and comprehensiveness of its principles and their application according to human needs across all times and places.

Chapter Two

FOUNDATIONS OF SYSTEMATIC THINKING IN THE QUR'AN

Thinking is the activity of the mind and its operation in pursuit of its objectives. One type of thinking is “scientific thinking” (*al-tafkīr al-‘ilmī*), which is a mode of consideration based on evidence supported by experience or proof. It involves abstraction and generalization, relies on the rules of logic, and is characterized by methodical structure. “Systematic thinking” (*al-tafkīr al-manhajī*) is similar in concept, where thinking is tied to a structured method. It can be defined as: a mental activity that follows clear and specific rules to arrive at truths.

Systematic thinking requires a person’s ability to think clearly and logically, to organize issues, evaluate probabilities, possess a complete conceptual understanding necessary for interpretation and explanation, and have sufficient tools for critique and guidance. All of these are the requirements of sound, structured thinking. Its foundations are rooted in a set of Qur’anic concepts related to the activation of both intellect and sensory faculties, as will be detailed.

The Intellect (‘*Aql*) and Its Status in Relation to Revelation

The Intellect (‘*Aql*): Linguistic and Technical/Specialized Definition

The term ‘*aql* (intellect) in language denotes restraint or withholding. In a technical or specialized sense, multiple definitions exist, centering on three essential meanings: the faculty by which knowledge is comprehended, knowledge itself, and some self-evident truths. In the methodological context, the meaning of intellect intended here is not “knowledge”—since knowledge is the goal and aim of method—nor is it the self-evident truths, as they are a source of knowledge. Rather, the intellect here refers to the faculty by which a person becomes prepared to receive knowledge, with its mental function being understanding and comprehension.

The Intellect (‘*Aql*) in the Qur’an

The root ‘*a-q-l* appears 49 times in the Qur’an—32 in Makkan chapters and

the rest in Madinan ones. This shows that the message of Islam in Makkah primarily focused on engaging the mind (‘*aql*) and promoting reflection and thought.

In the Qur’an, the root ‘*a-q-l* appears only in verb form, not as a noun—once in the past tense, and the rest in the present tense. This shows that the Qur’anic method defines the intellect as a mental cognitive function that must be continuously and actively engaged by every human being. It is invoked for its own sake, regardless of the subject or object of reflection.

The verb related to intellect is used in various linguistic constructions, such as being preceded by *la‘alla* (“so that you may understand”) or following a negative interrogative form (*afalā ta‘qilūn* – “Will you not use your reason?”), or linked to the mention of a “sign” or “signs” (*āyah/āyāt*), as in: “Indeed, in that is a sign for people who reason.” These expressions collectively serve as exhortations to use one’s intellect to reflect upon the clear signs—whether they are Qur’anic signs that present the method or universal signs that support the truth of these methodological verses.

The use of *la‘alla* suggests a hope that activating their intellect and contemplating those signs may guide people to accept what they are being invited to and truly come to know it. Conversely, when the Qur’an negates reasoning in matters where perceptual and intellectual faculties should suffice, it implies that the issue is not a lack of knowledge to be corrected, but rather a stagnation of the intellect—a failure to activate it through thought and reflection.

In some comprehensive contexts, the mention of intellect is linked to the call toward the right path and the straight way, such as in the latter verses of *Surat al-An‘ām* (6:151, 6:153). Thus, all the verses that mention the use of intellect, through their constructions, contexts, and themes, reinforce and urge the continuous application of reasoning and reflection as a way to arrive at acknowledgment of truth and the matters of the Qur’an.

The Qur’anic Terms Related to the Intellect (‘*Aql*) and Their Meanings

The term ‘*aql* in the Qur’an is related to many other words, among the most significant of which are: *hijr*, *nuhā*, *aḥlām*, and *lubb*. These are used in the form of verbal nouns, not to focus on the cognitive function of intellect per se, but rather to emphasize its effect—namely, the prevention of a person from engaging in reprehensible acts.

For example, *hijr* means prohibition or prevention, and intellect was called

hijr because it prevents a person from allowing their desires to lead them astray. *Nuhā*, which appears twice in the Qur'an, comes from *nuhyah*, meaning the intellect that forbids immoral behavior. *Ahlām*, which appears once in *Surat al-Tūr* (52:32), originally refers to controlling oneself from the agitation of anger. It was interpreted as "intellect" due to its role in such control.

The word *lubb* appears in 16 instances, always in the expression *ūlū al-albāb* ("those of sound understanding"). When used, it refers to pure intellect that is free from the impurities of the self and of desires. It benefits its possessor because of this purity—just as the core (*lubb*) is valuable compared to the outer shell. Verses that address *ūlū al-albāb* involve matters requiring deep contemplation and reflection and include exhortations toward piety, as in the verse: "Take provisions, but the best provision is piety" (2:197).

The Qur'an defines *ūlū al-albāb* through their characteristics in two places: the first is in *Surat Āl 'Imrān* (3:190–191), and the second is in *Surat al-Zumār* (39:17–18). These verses describe them as those who affirm God's Oneness, act in obedience to Him, listen to the best of speech, and follow the best of it. Thus, *ūlū al-albāb* are people of sound and complete intellect who recognize the consequences of matters. They possess both intellectual and behavioral excellence, combining the full cognitive function of the intellect with the moral effect seen in their piety and avoidance of wrongdoing.

It is also important to note the mention of the word *qalb* (heart), which has been interpreted by some as synonymous with the intellect and its locus, based on certain Qur'anic verses (such as 22:46). The relationship between the two may be explained as follows: both intellect and heart play a role in attaining knowledge and belief. The heart pumps blood to major organs, including the brain—the organ of the intellect. When a person attains understanding and knowledge through the intellect, it flows back to the heart to become firmly established as a belief or settled conviction. In this way, both the beginning and end of understanding and knowledge return to the heart, justifying its usage as a metaphor for the intellect, in line with Arab linguistic conventions of using one word for another due to close association, cause, or consequence.

The Relationship Between Intellect (‘*Aql*) and Revelation

The Qur'an's persistent call to activate the intellect (‘*aql*) affirms that Islam is a religion that does not impose its beliefs by force. Rather, it presents them,

engages in discussion, and encourages investigation and inquiry until one reaches belief and conviction in their truth.

A human being enters the world with no prior knowledge, as in God's statement: "And Allah brought you out of the wombs of your mothers not knowing a thing..." (16:78). The methodological position expected of humans is to activate their faculties of perception and intellect to assess the Prophet's message and the markers of its truthfulness, thereby arriving at belief in him. This position is well summarized in God's statement: "Say: I exhort you to one thing only: that you stand for God—singly or in pairs—and then reflect..." (34:46). This is a clear invitation for people to reflect, individually or with others, on the Prophet's case in order to scrutinize his claim and form a position.

Thus, scholars have concluded that the first obligation upon a human being is reflection that leads to knowledge of God. The disagreement among early scholars centered on how this obligation is proven—specifically, whether reason alone can establish moral judgment before the advent of revelation. This is the famous debate over *husn* (good) and *qubh* (evil) in actions: the Mu'tazilites held that what is judged good by reason is good, and what is judged evil is evil; the Ash'arites held that good is what the Shari'ah praises, and evil is what it forbids and warns against.

This debate may be refined by stating that actions inherently entail perfection or deficiency, which is recognized intellectually. These, in turn, imply harmony or repulsion, which is also intellectually recognized. Praise, blame, reward, and punishment logically follow from such intellectual recognition, but their actual implementation is conditional upon revelation, as in the verse: "We never punish until We have sent a messenger" (17:15). Therefore, rational recognition of good and evil does not by itself warrant punishment; what warrants it is the rejection of the messengers.

Hence, affirming rational moral judgment implies a shared, universal capacity among intellects to discern good and evil in actions. This forms a sufficient basis for divine revelation to address people. A person has the ability to evaluate actions and label them as good or evil and to make judgments accordingly. Revelation, when it arrives, becomes itself a matter for such rational evaluation, which may lead to accepting or rejecting it.

This evaluative ability is granted to humans by God's absolute will so that they can be held accountable—subject to reward or punishment—after the

arrival of revelation. Therefore, the relationship between intellect and revelation is ontological, epistemological, and methodological.

- **Ontologically**, revelation cannot achieve its purpose without addressing the intellect. Without reason, the truths of revelation cannot be fully comprehended, nor can its divine nature be unveiled or accepted. Even the religious sciences are not understood except through intellect.
- **Epistemologically**, revelation is a definitive source of knowledge for the prophet—he knows it with certainty as from God, through a path inaccessible to others. For others, revelation becomes a source of knowledge through investigation and reasoning. It complements other sources of knowledge, such as the universe, as well as the intellect in some types of necessary knowledge. Here, the intellect's role is to perceive and acquire knowledge through exploration of these sources: the universe as God's open book and the Qur'an as His recited book.
- **Methodologically**, the intellect is a tool for discovering and evaluating truth—not through unrestricted speculation, but by adhering to structured methodological conditions and following a disciplined, gradual, interconnected path of inquiry. This process relies on comparison, weighing evidence, moving from premises to conclusions, and from the known to the unknown. Revelation supports this intellectual journey by calling the intellect to reflect and providing safeguards against its inherent limitations—both in its cognitive capacity and its susceptibility to bias, desires, and external pressures. Revelation sets forth the principles and foundations necessary for maintaining integrity along the path to knowledge.

The Senses and Their Connection to Mental Processes

The senses are mentioned in the Qur'an in recognition of their epistemological value—as tools for perception. The Qur'an emphasizes the senses of hearing and sight because they are the most important means of perception and the strongest in acquiring knowledge. Through them, the evidences of true belief are grasped.

Hearing in the Qur'an

The root of *hearing* (*s-m-ʿ*) occurs in the Qur'an 185 times. It appears with the meaning of perceiving sound, as well as understanding what is heard—since understanding is the fruit of hearing. It also refers to accepting and taking heed of what is understood and acting accordingly, which is the highest

level of listening. The original meaning appears in contexts such as: “So when she heard of their scheming...” (12:31), referring to the use of the physical faculty of hearing.

However, when the Qur’an urges humans to activate their hearing, it aims to elevate it to the level of understanding and acceptance, as in the verse: “O you who have believed, obey Allah and His Messenger and do not turn away from him while you hear. And do not be like those who say, ‘We hear,’ but they do not hear” (8:20–21). Also, in the command to listen: “So when the Qur’an is recited, listen to it and pay attention that you may receive mercy” (7: 204).

Thus, hearing exists in levels, in terms of what God expects from His servants in response to His Book. The highest level for the believer is to hear, comprehend, reflect, and act. The noble rank of this level is confirmed by the fact that hearing is described as an act of worship, coupled with a command to be mindful of God, as in: “So fear Allah and listen and obey” (64:16).

Moreover, the exhortation to hearing is not limited to contexts about the Qur’an or calls to piety and obedience. It also appears in discussions of societal laws and cosmic signs, such as: “And Allah sends down water from the sky and gives life thereby to the earth after its death. Indeed, that is a sign for a people who listen” (16:65). This indicates that the encouragement to hear applies broadly to the entire domain of knowledge. Its methodological activation lies in the integration between the sensory level of perceiving sound and its impact on understanding and reflection.

Sight and Its Synonyms in the Qur’an

The term *baṣar* (sight) in the Qur’an refers to the sense of vision and is often associated with its organ—the eye, as in: “Do they have feet with which they walk? Or hands with which they strike? Or eyes with which they see?” (7:195). It is frequently paired with hearing to express God’s blessing on humans through the gift of perceptual faculties.

Baṣar refers both to the physical perception with the eyes and the faculty that enables one to perceive visible things. It can also be used for the insight of the heart—what is called *baṣīrah* (perception/clarity). The root occurs around 150 times in the Qur’an. While its most common usage is in the literal sense of physical sight, many exegetes indicate that in many contexts it metaphorically refers to insight and knowledge. This is likely the case in references to “people of insight” (*ūlū al-abṣār*), as in: “...a lesson for people of

insight” (3:13, 24:44, 59:2). Here, *sight* moves beyond perceiving physical objects to mean reflective contemplation that leads to knowledge.

One related term is *nazar* (to look), which means to observe something with the eye or to direct the gaze toward something in order to see it. It also implies inner contemplation for the sake of acquiring knowledge—including both outer sight and inner insight. The root *n-z-r* appears about 139 times and is interpreted variously as reflection and consideration. This is its dominant meaning in commands and rhetorical prompts like: “Do they not look...?,” “Have they not considered...?,” “Look...,” “Let him consider...” and similar expressions.

In the Qur’anic context, the command to *look* can refer to both visual and intellectual contemplation. The Qur’an intentionally uses the term without restricting it to one or the other, encouraging full engagement of all faculties—sight and insight—beginning with what is immediate and essential in life, like food: “Let man look at his food” (80:24). It extends to more subtle matters, such as reflecting on the substance from which humans were created: “So let man consider from what he was created” (86:5). Or reflecting on the way things are created, which the Qur’an stresses in various contexts—whether the subject of knowledge is cosmic signs: “Do they not look at the camels—how they are created?” (88:17)—or the fate of past nations, which is invoked when commanding travel through the earth, linked to reflection on historical consequences.

This higher level of reflection also appears in the Qur’an’s use of the word *ru’yah* (seeing), whose root occurs more than 300 times, often in expressions like: “Have you not seen...?” These often appear in narratives about the fates of earlier nations, cosmic signs, or the behavior of disbelievers. Since these are not things one can see with physical eyes, the intended meaning is metaphorical—referring to inner, intellectual vision that leads to truth.

Thus, the vocabulary of the senses—hearing, seeing, looking, and observing—contains two layers: one physical and material, and the other metaphorical, referring to intellectual, reflective, or epistemic perception. The Qur’an emphasizes the second layer, especially when addressing subtle and profound topics across cosmological, human, societal, and historical domains. In many cases, it pairs this with a call to understand the *how* (the manner of creation), which represents a deeper level of perception than mere recognition of *what* exists. This shows that the methodological activation of the senses in the Qur’an extends beyond raw sensory input, involving their utilization within

an integrated sensory-intellectual framework that supports broader cognitive processes.

The Connection Between Senses and Mental Processes in the Qur'an

The connection between the senses and the intellect appears in multiple Qur'anic passages. Most notably, the senses are linked to the heart, as in: "And Allah brought you out of your mothers' wombs not knowing anything, and He made for you hearing, sight, and hearts, that you might give thanks" (16:78). Disabling the senses is considered equivalent to disabling the intellect, as they are its instruments. God says: "[They are] deaf, dumb, and blind—so they do not understand" (2:171).

The senses are also tied to higher cognitive functions, as expressed by terms such as reflection (*tafakkur*), deep understanding (*tafaqquh*), and contemplation (*tadabbur*). Although these terms emphasize the intellect and its activation, their linguistic meanings and Qur'anic contexts assign them a role that is deeper than mere rationality. In fact, the Qur'an treats them as among its core aims, as in: "...And We sent down to you the Reminder so that you may explain clearly to mankind what has been sent down to them, and that they may reflect" (16:44).

This connection to the senses is evident in two ways:

1. The pairing of sensory terms with cognitive processes, such as in: "Say, 'Look at what is there in the heavens and the earth...'" (10:101), and: "Indeed, in that is a reminder for whoever has a heart or listens while he is present [in mind]" (50:37), and similar extended passages in *Surat al-Nahl* (verses 10–17) and *Surat al-Rûm* (verses 17–28).
2. The pairing of cognitive verbs like *reflection* and *remembrance* with parables (*amthāl*)—which the Qur'an uses in argumentation. The parable usually presents an example agreed upon even by opponents, to bridge between the abstract and the perceptible, hoping they will reflect on it and be guided to the truth, as in: "...It brings forth its fruit at all times by the permission of its Lord..." (14:25).

The Qur'anic text establishes a strong link between reason and sensory experience. Just as sensory action contains rational justification, intellectual activity depends on sensory grounds. No matter how abstract a concept may become, it retains sensory roots—without which it would not be possible to connect abstract reasoning with empirical or tangible examples. The impact

of this *sensory-intellectual interaction* is evident in the Qur'anic method of argument, as will be discussed further.

Chapter Three

PRINCIPLES OF METHODOLOGICAL CONDUCT IN THE QUR'AN

Cognitive activity is influenced by the human self and its decisive role in either reaching the truth and knowledge or turning away from them. The Qur'an is keen on refining the self through ethical principles that regulate the scientific field (*al-majāl al-ʿilmī*) and guide the development of knowledge. These ethical foundations are referred to as the “principles of methodological conduct”—that is, the moral values that direct the researcher's behavior during scientific inquiry.

These principles represent the ethics and human values of scientific research and include two dimensions: the values that must be upheld, and the traits that must be avoided. This study seeks to identify the fundamental value in each of these two categories—commitment and abstention—and to clarify the significance of methodological values through them.

Methodical Education (*Al-Tarbiyyah al-Manhajīyyah*) in Standing for the Truth

The Concept of Methodical Education (*Al-Tarbiyyah al-Manhajīyyah*) and Its Principles in Qur'anic Contexts

Since systematic thinking is founded on the activation of both reason and the senses at the highest levels of perception to reach valid evidence and follow it, the ethical dimension—linked to behavior—rests on the same foundation and complements it. It aims to train the human self to consistently follow evidence that reason and sensory perception deem valid, and to give precedence to it over personal whims and desires. This process of nurturing the self toward that goal is called “methodical education” (*al-tarbiyyah al-manhajīyyah*).

This education is based on a core principle, which can be summarized as follows:

Truth is the ultimate goal, and the evidence leading to it is what must be followed. The human self must prioritize this over those desires and inclinations that are deleterious, at all stages of scientific inquiry—from the psychological readiness that precedes it, through its practice by observation and reasoning, to the commitment to its results and their application in real life.

To ground this principle in the Qur'an, one can examine the most significant contexts that establish its meaning and then attempt to derive a Qur'anic expression or concept that refers to it. A starting point is God's statement: "Say: I exhort you to one thing only—that you stand up for God, in pairs and individually, and then reflect..." (34:46). This verse is a pure call to a methodology for seeking truth, offering guidance on how to prepare oneself for reflection and contemplation. It is a singular call: if fulfilled, the method becomes sound and the path straight. It is the call to stand for God with sincerity and to abandon those personal desires that are deleterious, partisanship, and self-interest.

A person must adopt a neutral stance before the evidence, be eager to find and follow it, even if it lies with an opponent. This is indicated in the verse: "Say: 'Who provides for you from the heavens and the earth?' Say: 'Allah. Then surely we or you are upon guidance or in clear error'" (34:24). This impartial approach is exemplified in the conduct of many prophets, such as Abraham (peace be upon him), who said to his people: "Which of the two parties has more right to security, if you should know? Those who believe and do not mix their belief with wrongdoing..." (6:81-82). Here, he chose to say "Which of the two..." rather than "We have more right to security." He did not outright say that their method was false and his was true—demonstrating the utmost impartiality in debate. This approach is further affirmed in other verses (such as in 11:35 and 34:25).

The Concept of "Standing for the Truth" as the Foundation of Methodical Education (*Al-Tarbiyyah al-Manhajyyah*)

If we wish to identify a Qur'anic concept that encompasses the ethical foundation of scientific inquiry, we can begin with the word "standing" (*qiyām*), which appears in the verse: "That you stand up for God..." (34:46). This is a central concept in the Qur'an. Its root appears over 650 times, often linked to essential matters of religion such as establishing prayer and upholding

God's boundaries. It is also associated with the religion itself, as in: "The religion of uprightness..." (9:36).

The word *qiyām* is also employed in a context similar to that of verse 34:46, as in: "O you who believe, be persistently standing firm in justice, witnesses for Allah..." (4:135) and "O you who believe, be persistently standing firm for Allah, witnesses in justice..." (5:8).

The term *qawwām* is an emphatic form of the verb *qāma* (to stand up or undertake), meaning someone who consistently takes charge of and upholds a matter with full care. The command in the verse "Be *qawwāmīn* for Allah" is a call to make this stance an integral part of one's being.

In the verse from *Surat al-Nisā'* (4:135), *qiyām* is linked to *justice for the sake of God*, especially in testimony—one of the primary paths to truth and knowledge. Thus, it encompasses all statements and actions in which a person must act sincerely for God and uphold truth in bearing witness.

From the two verses, we learn that one must *stand for God with justice and testify for Him*, maintaining impartiality—whether that impartiality is challenged by personal love (for oneself, parents, relatives, or important individuals in society) or by hatred and animosity, which may push one toward injustice.

Therefore, the concept of "standing for God" is a fundamental Qur'anic principle. And since God is the Truth—as in His statement: "That is because Allah is the Truth..." (22:6)—it can be derived that the concept of "standing for the truth" stems from this.

This concept refers to standing up for truth with sincerity—free from desire, bias, or societal pressures—and to maintaining neutrality in the face of evidence, earnestly seeking it and adhering to it regardless of its source or who presents it.

This can be precisely defined as: "Standing for the truth is the act of striving with sincerity to seek the truth and prioritize it under all circumstances."

The preference for the phrase "*standing for the truth*" over "standing with the truth" lies in the fact that the latter implies the person already possesses the truth and then commits to it. In contrast, "standing for the truth" conveys a broader meaning. It indicates that the person is exerting sincere effort in pursuit of truth, seeking to identify and reach it—and then commit to it and act upon it once attained.

Protection from Following Base Desires (*Hawā*) and the Integration of Values in Qur'anic Methodology

The principle of *standing for the truth*, which underpins the ethical commitment in scientific research, is paralleled by the necessity of being safeguarded from anything that obstructs the attainment of knowledge. Perhaps the most dangerous of such obstacles is following base desires or unrestrained desires of the lower self (*hawā*), since such desires affect the direction of rational conviction. If directed toward self-love, it breeds arrogance; if directed toward lusts, it diverts a person's efforts and capabilities toward that which aligns with their inclinations.

Therefore, the Shari'ah decisively prohibits the influence of base desire, because once such desire becomes part of the reasoning process, the result will be nothing but the very kind of desire-following that is condemned—thus violating divine guidance and corrupting reasoning.

Protection from Following Base or Unrestrained Desires of the Lower Self (*Hawā*)

The word *hawā* (base desire or unrestrained desire of the lower self) and its derivatives occur in the Qur'an in over 40 places. Its root meaning relates to falling and emptiness. The desire of the soul combines both meanings, for the one who follows it is devoid of all good and is led by it into what is improper.

The Qur'an strongly condemns following *hawā* in all the contexts in which it is mentioned. Most of these contexts pertain to the epistemological and methodological fields, often appearing alongside references to *knowledge*, as in: "But those who wrong follow their *hawā* without knowledge..." (30:29). Or with references to *method*, as in: "...To each of you We prescribed a law and a methodology. If Allah had willed, He would have made you one community, but He tests you in what He has given you..." (5:48).

Thus, following *hawā* stands in direct opposition to standing for the truth. This is made clear in the verse: "O you who have believed, be persistently standing firm in justice, witnesses for Allah, even if it be against yourselves or parents and relatives. Whether one is rich or poor, Allah is more worthy of both. So follow not *hawā*, lest you not be just..." (4:135). Here, the phrase "lest you not be just" emphasizes that *justice and following hawā cannot coexist*.

Hence, following *hawā* contradicts systematic thinking, which requires considering matters with objectivity and neutrality. By definition, *hawā* is an opinion that arises from passion, not from evidence. Therefore, the Qur'an explicitly distinguishes between the one who possesses clear proof and the one who follows *hawā*—a contrast between objectivity and subjectivity: “Is he who is upon clear evidence from his Lord like the one whose evil deeds have been made appealing to him and they follow their *hawā*?” (47:14).

The Integration of Moral Values in Qur'anic Methodology

If *hawā* is the root of the blameworthy traits that the Qur'an warns against, and if following it is the most severe barrier to arriving at truth and knowledge, then many related traits also affect the integrity of a person's cognitive activity. Among the most significant of these are *arrogance* (*kibr*) and *blind imitation* (*taqlid*).

Taqlid is defined as following someone else in word or deed, believing in the truth of their position without investigation or reflection upon the evidence. The Qur'an firmly opposes stagnation and imitation in all its forms, including imitation of forefathers, elders, leaders, and religious authorities, as in: “They took their rabbis and monks as lords besides Allah...” (9:31).

The Qur'anic method is grounded in the individual's intellectual freedom and responsibility for their convictions, which must stem from a solid intellectual foundation. A person should not yield to their *hawā*, interests, or inherited societal traditions. Rather, *truth alone* should be sought through contemplation, reasoning, and inquiry.

A person's moral character—expressed in their aspiration to uphold noble virtues and higher values—applies equally to their research activity and intellectual conduct. These are governed by a set of methodological values. The Qur'an is concerned with showing the practical impact of these values by recounting the stories of past nations—especially the People of the Book—and describing their attitudes toward the truth that was revealed to them and what came afterward.

Most of the People of the Book fall into one of two categories: either obstinate scholars or blind imitators among the masses. Regarding the general masses, the Qur'an states: “And among them are unlettered people who do not know the Scripture except through hearsay. They only assume” (2:78). They neither know the revealed Book nor understand its contents. As for their scholars,

although they had attained knowledge and recognized the truth, the Qur'an clarifies that many of them act in contradiction to that knowledge. This contradiction is evident both in their inner convictions and in their outward behavior. The Qur'an mentions various manifestations of their deviation, such as: "Among the Jews are those who distort words from their proper places..." (4:46), and "But because of their breaking of the covenant, We cursed them and made their hearts hard..." (5:13), and "Do you hope they will believe you while a party of them used to hear the words of Allah then distort it knowingly after they understood it?" (2:75). These verses indicate that their rejection and distortion of the truth did not stem from honest intellectual disagreement, but from corrupted inner selves drowned in greed and *hawā*.

The Qur'an also offers a noble description that can represent those who uphold divine methodology and embody methodological values. That is the description of "*al-rabbāniyyūn*" (the God-devoted scholars), found in the verse: "But be godly scholars of the Lord because of what you have taught of the Scripture and what you have studied" (3:79). These are people who have reached the highest level of embodying the attributes worthy of being affiliated with the Lord of the Worlds. They are described as those engaged in teaching and nurturing others and using all of this in managing the affairs and interests of creation.

Chapter Four

THE IMPORTANCE OF EVIDENCE AND THE METHOD OF REASONING IN THE QUR'AN

The question of *evidence* constitutes the foundation of scientific methodology and the essence and soul of scientific thinking. All sciences rest upon and submit to evidence. The Qur'an presents its issues accompanied by proofs and clear signs and calls for following arguments and evidence as a path to faith in it. Other Islamic sources of legislation also rely on evidence and draw their legitimacy and authority from it.

The Importance of Evidence in the Qur'an

Qur'anic Vocabulary that Signifies the Importance of Evidence

The word *dalīl* (evidence) in Arabic refers to revealing and clarifying something hidden. Although this exact term is infrequently used in the Qur'an and does not appear directly with the technical meaning of "proof" or "argument leading to certainty," its significance is confirmed by its synonyms: *ḥujjah* (proof), *ṣulṭān* (authority), *burhān* (clear proof), *āyah* (sign), and *ʿalāmah* (mark)—all of which belong to a semantic field centered around the concept of evidence.

The word *burhān* occurs eight times in the Qur'an, always as a noun. It denotes conclusive proof that validates a claim and leads to knowledge. It is closely related in evidentiary strength to *ṣulṭān*, whose root appears 39 times in the Qur'an. Linguistically, it carries two meanings: authority/proof, and power/dominance—with the usage related to proof being more frequent.

Other central Qur'anic terms include *āyah* (sign) and *bayyinah* (clear proof). These retain their linguistic meaning as signs marked by strong reliability. They often occur in reference to:

- Cosmic signs
- The miracles of prophets that confirm their truthfulness
- Legal verses that clarify the practical legislative method

These terms appear in nearly all Qur'anic chapters and are used as *evidentiary tools* for the Qur'an's most important claims—God's existence, His Oneness, prophethood, and divine legislation.

The word *ḥujjah* (argument or proof) also belongs to this semantic field. Its linguistic origin refers to purposeful intent. Its root occurs in 33 places in the Qur'an—20 of which pertain to the meaning of proof and evidence. These appear mostly in verbal forms (*ḥājjā*, *tuḥājūnī*, *ḥājajtum*, etc.), which indicate mutual argumentation, where each party presents what supports their claim or refutes the other's.

The term thus aligns with other Qur'anic terms like *muḥājah* (argumentation), *mujādalah* (disputation), and *munāẓarah* (debate). The semantic field of *evidence* thus expands to include expressions such as dispute, contention, debate, dialogue, and argument. Consequently, the Qur'an as a whole

becomes a *dialogical text*, marked by a striking frequency of interactive exchanges, arguments, and engagements with different perspectives.

The Qur'anic discourse is inherently argumentative, built on presenting opinions, discussing them, and refuting them. Through this structure, all core issues—including belief and doctrine—are addressed through a reasoning method that presents arguments and requires that they be valid and truthful.

The Importance of Evidence in Qur'anic Linguistic Constructions and Contexts

The Qur'anic style employs vocabulary related to evidence in many linguistic constructions and contexts, emphasizing its importance. A notable example is the repeated divine command, expressed four times with nearly identical wording: “Say: Bring your proof...”. This expression (which appears in *Surat al-Baqarah*: 111, *Surat al-Anbiyā*: 24, *Surat al-Naml*: 64, and *Surat al-Qaṣaṣ*: 75) affirms a foundational Qur'anic principle: “No claim without proof.”

In two of these verses (*Surat al-Baqarah*: 111; and *Surat al-Naml*: 64), the command is conditioned by sincerity and truth: “If you are truthful...”. The use of the conditional particle *in* (“if”), which implies doubt, conveys an educational message to the community: one must remain *neutral* when faced with competing claims and evaluate all evidence fairly. Even if a person is confident in the correctness of their own proof, they must leave room for the possibility of the other party's truth, listen to their evidence, and evaluate it according to the measure of truth.

This Qur'anic expression consistently appears in contexts related to divine oneness, criticizing the method of following false gods or beliefs without proof or authority. It should not be interpreted as implying that polytheists ever had legitimate proof of their claims—rather, it affirms the *absence* of evidence in such claims. At the same time, it *elevates the status of evidence* in divine religion, making it the standard by which all claims are validated or rejected, regardless of their content.

The Qur'anic style even suggests—hypothetically—that if someone were to bring proof for idolatry, it would have to be accepted. This extreme hypothetical is used to underscore the *supreme status of evidence* and reasoning. The actual aim of these Qur'anic expressions is to *mock, rebuke, and expose the falsehood* of the opponents' claims by showing that it is impossible for them to bring valid evidence.

This is reinforced by the verse that refers to what the disbelievers present as a “proof” (*hujjah*): “They said: ‘There is nothing but our worldly life; we die and live, and nothing destroys us but time.’ But they have no knowledge of that; they only speculate. And when Our clear verses are recited to them, their only argument is to say, ‘Bring back our forefathers, if you are truthful’” (45: 24–25). This passage strongly highlights the necessity of supporting any claim made in dialogue with evidence. Some form of reasoning or proof must back any statement presented in an argumentative context. Once offered, it becomes subject to *investigation and scrutiny* in accordance with the method of truth and correctness.

The emphasis on evidence is also found in many Qur’anic passages (such as those in *Surat al-Anbiyā’*: 16–24 and *Surat al-Naml*: 59–70), which present a series of successive signs, whether cosmic or human, and combine them with concepts such as:

- Activating the intellect (e.g., reflection, remembrance)
- Engaging the senses (e.g., hearing, seeing)
- Truth and knowledge (as the ultimate goals of evidence)

In these passages, one can identify *methodological contexts* in which the core elements of reasoning are integrated and systematically employed to provide evidence for the foundational claims of the Qur’an.

The Method of Reasoning (*Manhaj al-Istidlāl*) in the Qur’an

Clarifying the Concept of the Method of Reasoning (*Manhaj al-Istidlāl*)

Given the significance the Qur’an assigns to evidence (*al-dalīl*), it is essential to clarify the method of reasoning (*manhaj al-istidlāl*) it contains. To begin, one must distinguish between *evidence*, the *method of reasoning*, and the *style* (*uslūb*) of argumentation.

Evidence refers to what guides toward revealing and clarifying a hidden matter. It consists of both *content* (*maḍmūn*) and *formulation* (*ṣiyāghah*)

- The *content* refers to the essence and message of the evidence, relying on rational or transmitted premises.
- The *formulation* refers to the manner in which the evidence is expressed,

known as the *style of reasoning*. In the Qur'an, this includes recurring linguistic features that form a unique rhetorical style characteristic of the Qur'anic discourse.

The *method of reasoning* is based on the concept of *istidlāl* (deduction/inference), which is the process of establishing evidence to prove a conclusion. It is a mental operation that involves presenting and establishing proofs, deriving one proposition from another to arrive at a new judgment—different from the premises—from which it was derived. This process follows specific rules to ensure valid movement from the known to the unknown.

Accordingly, the search for evidence that leads to truth—through reflection and the activation of rational and sensory faculties—takes place through an organized sequence of steps. This can be termed the *method of reasoning*, which appears in two forms:

1. **The method of reasoning *with* the Qur'an**, considering it as evidence and a legislative source.
2. **The method of reasoning *within* the Qur'an**, referring to the various rational proofs it offers—whether for the Qur'an's authenticity or its theological content, such as belief in God, prophethood, and the afterlife.

Consideration (*I'tibār*) as the Qur'anic Method of Reasoning (*Manhaj al-Istidlāl*)

The method of reasoning in the Qur'an can be distilled into a fundamental two-step process:

1. *Activating knowledge faculties* through engagement with the observable, physical world.
2. *Transitioning from that engagement* to intellectual contemplation of unseen realities.

The Qur'an makes the foundation of certainty in knowledge *either directly sensory or connected to sensory input* through indirect means. The evidences provided may be directly empirical or indirectly linked to observation. However, the Qur'an does not confine human understanding to sensory knowledge alone; rather, it always intends for this to serve as a bridge to the *unseen*, which lies beyond sensory perception.

The unseen (*al-ghayb*) encompasses all that is ordinarily imperceptible to the senses, ranging from the physical universe—where every hidden aspect is potentially knowable—to metaphysical realities such as God, prophethood,

and the resurrection, which form the essence of the Qur'anic message. Thus, the Qur'anic method encourages the human intellect to go beyond appearances and sensory phenomena toward inquiry into the unseen. It emphasizes *faith-based issues* in particular, as these are the heart of the Qur'anic call.

This method of continual transition from the seen to the unseen is expressed in the Qur'an with the term *i'tibār* (consideration or reflection). *I'tibār* signifies moving from one state to another—bridging the gap from the senses to the intellect, from ignorance to knowledge. This represents the core of the Qur'anic method of reasoning.

The significance of *i'tibār* is reinforced by its association with *āyāt* (signs)—those objects of contemplation and reflection, whether cosmic or human:

“Indeed, in that is a lesson for those of insight...” (24:44)—referring to people of vision and discernment.

“Indeed, in their stories is a lesson for those of understanding...” (12:111)—referring to those of intellect who think, contemplate, and benefit from knowledge.

This method of consideration (*i'tibār*), which characterizes Qur'anic reasoning, applies to all kinds of evidence in the Qur'an—whether based on empirical, sensory proof or rational, theoretical argument. It is clearly evident in the Abrahamic method, particularly in the story of Prophet Abraham, where we see him seeking evidence and debating using both:

- Rational reasoning
- Empirical reasoning, through direct observation and physical demonstration—whether with himself, his father, his people, or the king of his time.

The Integration and Distinction of the Qur'anic Method of Reasoning (*Manhaj al-Istidlāl*) from Human Methodologies (*Al-Manāhij al-Insāniyyah*)

The Qur'anic method of consideration is based on employing both *sensory observation* and *rational deduction* to arrive at certainty. It reflects a duality in epistemological stance:

- In terms of *sources* of knowledge: **sense** and **reason**
- In terms of *objects* of knowledge: the **seen** and the **unseen**

This renders it a *comprehensive methodology* that includes the foundational principles of both empirical and rational evidence. It adopts every sound and valid principle from human methodologies while maintaining its own distinctiveness. For example:

- When *deductive reasoning* is required (such as analogy or inference), the Qur'an offers analogical proofs like the *resurrection* proven by analogy to the *initial creation*, as in: "As He originated you, so will you return" (7:29).
- In *inductive reasoning*, the verse: "Travel through the land and observe how He began creation..." (29:20), suggests the inductive process of observing historical events and remnants of past nations to extract universal patterns and laws governing human societies.
- As for *analogical representation* (*tamthīl*), the Qur'an is rich with examples of similes and metaphors that illustrate abstract ideas with concrete imagery.

When it comes to *empirical methodology*, many verses of the Qur'an reflect it, such as:

- *Guided observation*, as in: "Then look again—do you see any flaws? Then look again and yet again; your vision will return humbled and weary" (67: 3–4). This is a directed, repeated observation designed to lead to a definitive conclusion.
- *Direct sensory observation* is also emphasized as a method of attaining real knowledge, as in: "Or did We create the angels female while they were watching?" (37:150).
- *Experimental inquiry* is similarly evident in the story of the man who passed by a ruined town and was brought back to life (2:259).

The distinctiveness and superiority of the Qur'anic method of *consideration* (*ītibār*) over human reasoning methods can be demonstrated through its differences from the approaches of early philosophers and logicians—whether in terminology, argumentation, or debate techniques. It also differs from the *empirical scientific method*, particularly in its ability to transition from reflection on natural phenomena to knowledge of their Creator.

While the empirical method acknowledges the truth of a material and sensory-based claim through observation and experimentation, it does not reach the level of the Qur'anic method. The Qur'an's method is grounded in

contemplation of the universe and its signs, treating them as observed and necessary premises that lead to knowledge of the *unseen realities* proclaimed by the Qur'an.

Thus, the study of the Qur'anic method of reasoning—its integration and uniqueness—and the effort to apply its influence to human methodologies and knowledge fields still demands more attention and detailed study. There is a need for deeper exploration of its components and resolution of its more complex issues. One such area is the concept of miracles (*mu'jizāt*), a vital topic closely tied to evidence and reasoning, and it holds a notable place within the Qur'anic scientific methodology.

The Evidence of Miracles (*Mu'jizāt*) and Their Place in the Qur'anic Methodology

The Concept and Significance of the Miracle (*Mu'jizah*)

The concept of miracle (*mu'jizah*) is closely tied to the idea of *evidence* in the Qur'anic discourse. In the Qur'an, miracles are portrayed as *signs and proofs* given to prophets as divine confirmation of their truthfulness. According to many scholars, miracles are the *primary and definitive proof* of a prophet's authenticity. This is because belief in a religion fundamentally requires belief in the prophethood of the one who conveys it—and such belief, in turn, rests on the validation provided by miracles, particularly *empirical (sensory) miracles*, which are observable and tangible.

Thus, miracles are seen as essential to the prophetic mission: the truth of a prophet is confirmed by them, and faith in the prophet depends on their occurrence. However, this is not an absolute rule, as the missions of earlier prophets were often limited to their own people, a fact supported by Qur'anic verses such as: “To ‘Ād, We sent their brother Hūd...” (Qur'an 7:65), and by the authentic hadith: “Every prophet was sent to his people specifically, but I have been sent to all people.” (*Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī* 335; *Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim* 521).

The miraculous nature of a sensory miracle does not lie solely in *what* was done, but in *how* it was done and the *cause* behind it. Scholars differentiate between miracles and magic in this regard: although both may appear to break natural laws, magic operates through specific, known causes that can be learned and repeated. A miracle, by contrast, is based on a divine cause

that cannot be known, controlled, or replicated. In some cases, a miracle might resemble something within human ability, but the way it occurs—through divine support and an inaccessible cause—sets it apart. The miracle is thus not about performing something unimaginable, but about achieving it through a means *only God can grant*, uniquely to His prophet.

The Role of Miracles (*Mu'jizāt*) in Qur'anic Methodology

Based on the above, an empirical miracle may be defined as: “An extraordinary event during the time of a prophetic mission, linked to the claim of prophethood, and occurring through a cause that cannot be replicated.” It is methodologically tied to prophethood because they serve as *proofs* of a prophet's truth, in a way that aligns with the nature of their claim. Thus, through miracles—and with divine support—the prophet breaks the chain of ordinary cause and effect, performing an act via a *unique cause* that no other human can replicate. This results in a *methodological harmony* between *evidence* and *claim*.

Since these sensory miracles are no longer accessible due to their historical context and cannot be reproduced through the exact causes that enabled them, understanding their significance in Qur'anic scientific methodology requires closer reflection. The Qur'an refers to these miracles as signs of the prophets, calling them *burhān* (proof) and *sulṭān* (authority). They are not outside the Qur'an's general epistemological framework but are part of it. Rather than being exceptions to natural laws, they are *definitive proofs* that confirm and reinforce those laws. The sensory signs in nature, which humans are urged to observe and harness, are complemented by the prophetic miracles, which awaken the intellect to the systems and laws that govern the universe.

Belief in miracles establishes an intellectual position that affirms the existence of a Creator, one who governs the universe with order and precision and who also has the power to suspend or replace that order. Just as the cosmic signs in the Qur'an are meant to demonstrate God's power, encourage reflection, and guide the human being to utilize natural laws in building civilization, and just as legal verses call for contemplation of divine wisdom and practical application, the miracles of the prophets also serve multiple purposes: to prove God's power; to verify the truth of prophethood; and to invite reflection on the causes that might reproduce the effects of the miracle (its real-world outcomes), even if the original cause remains exclusive to the prophet. For example:

- The *parting of the sea* for Moses had the effect of enabling safe passage across the water. While the original cause—striking the sea with a staff—cannot be replicated, humans have since discovered other means of crossing seas, whether over or under them.
- The *Night Journey (Isrā’)* of the Prophet Muhammad, the only explicitly mentioned physical miracle in the Qur’an, involved traveling a great distance in a very short time. While the Prophet’s specific means—riding al-Burāq—is inaccessible, humans have since developed material means to achieve similar outcomes.
- The *transportation of the throne of Bilqīs* (Queen of Sheba) is another case. The miracle’s effect was the rapid transfer of the throne, nearly instantaneously. This affirms the possibility of such a phenomenon and encourages exploration into how similar outcomes might be achieved materially, inspired by the reality of the miracle.

In this light, understanding empirical miracles beyond merely accepting them, by considering their real-world outcomes and effects, can incorporate them into the Qur’anic methodology itself. They become a source of inspiration for scientific inquiry, affirming that similar outcomes may be possible through natural means, even if the original causes were miraculous. Although prophetic miracles occurred through divine intervention, humans may be enabled by God—through research, reflection, and scientific method—to achieve comparable results, following the path laid by these miracles as part of the Qur’anic worldview.

CONCLUSION

This study has explored the foundational role of systematic thought and methodological reasoning as articulated in the Qur’anic discourse. Beginning with a conceptual clarification of *manhaj* (method) and *manhajiiyyah* (methodology), the text established a clear terminological and philosophical framework for understanding how the Qur’an constructs and communicates guidance. This was further supported by an analysis of how the Qur’an itself embodies method through its structure, purpose, and core characteristics.

Chapter One introduced the key conceptual foundations of the study, beginning with a clarification of the terms *manhaj* and *manhajiiyyah*, and explored

related concepts critical to understanding the Qur'an's epistemological and pedagogical orientation. It also outlined the defining characteristics of the Qur'anic method, highlighting its balance between divine revelation and human reason.

Chapter Two examined the epistemological foundations of Qur'anic thinking by focusing on the status of the intellect (*‘aql*) and the senses as complementary tools in the pursuit of truth. The Qur'an affirms the significance of human reason and sensory experience while situating them within a divinely guided framework, thereby offering a holistic model of knowledge acquisition that integrates revelation with rational inquiry.

In Chapter Three, the study turned to the ethical and pedagogical dimensions of Qur'anic methodology. It highlighted how the Qur'an cultivates a methodical consciousness (*al-tarbiyyah al-manhajyyah*) in the believer—particularly in standing for truth and resisting the influence of base desires (*hawā*). Here, the integration of values such as justice, sincerity, and accountability was shown to be essential to the Qur'anic conception of method, reinforcing that methodology in the Qur'an is not merely procedural but also deeply moral.

Chapter Four addressed the centrality of evidence (*al-dalīl*) and the Qur'anic approach to reasoning (*manhaj al-istidlāl*). It demonstrated that the Qur'an appeals to various forms of evidence—empirical, rational, and revelatory—as part of a coherent strategy for persuasion and guidance. Special attention was given to the role of miracles (*mu‘jizāt*) as a unique form of divine evidence. The discussion emphasized that the Qur'an differentiates between miracles and other extraordinary phenomena, such as magic, on the basis of their source, purpose, and inimitability, thereby reinforcing the Qur'anic commitment to rational and verifiable forms of belief.

Taken together, these chapters reveal that the Qur'an is not only a source of spiritual guidance but also a model of methodical reasoning, epistemic balance, and ethical discipline. Its methodology is comprehensive, encompassing the intellect, the senses, moral values, and divine signs—all directed toward the cultivation of a just and truth-oriented individual and society. By grounding its guidance in both reason and revelation, the Qur'an offers a distinctive epistemological paradigm that remains relevant for contemporary methodological and philosophical inquiry.

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IIIT Books-In-Brief Series is a valuable collection of the Institute's key publications written in condensed form to give readers a core understanding of the main contents of the original.

The Qur'an presents not only a comprehensive framework of spiritual and ethical guidance but also a distinctive model of systematic thought and methodological reasoning. This short work aims to examine the Qur'anic approach to *manhaj* (method) and *manhajiyah* (methodology) by exploring how the sacred text cultivates rational inquiry, integrates moral values, and appeals to various forms of evidence in its discourse. Far from offering abstract or disjointed teachings, the Qur'an engages the human intellect, sense perception, and spiritual conscience through a coherent and purposeful methodology inviting readers to reflect deeply on their lives and the world around them while fostering a holistic understanding of faith and existence.

